



She Drew Small

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 She told the story of a revolution in the drawings of a child, and that turned out to be the truest way to tell it. Marjane Satrapi, who died in Paris on Thursday at fifty-six, made her name with a black-and-white comic about a girl in Tehran. The girl was herself.

2 Persepolis began appearing in 2000, four slim volumes of line drawings: a daughter of educated, watchful parents growing up as the Iran of her childhood was remade around her, then sent abroad to Europe, alone and young. The drawings were plain. A veil, a schoolyard, a soldier at a corner. Out of those small panels came a portrait of a country that years of reporting had left, for most outside readers, a blur.

3 That was her method, and her quiet argument: that the enormous is best approached through the small. A revolution rendered as a quarrel with her grandmother. Exile rendered as a teenager friendless in a borrowed language. She trusted the particular to carry the general, and it did.

4 And in 2007 she and Vincent Paronnaud turned the books into an animated film, keeping the stark black and white when color would have been easier and more salable. It shared the Jury Prize at Cannes. It was nominated for the Academy Award for best animated feature, and with that nomination Satrapi became the first woman the category had ever named. She went on to other things: a novel and film called *Chicken with Plums*, books drawn at a kitchen table, films in registers far from where she began, and, near the end, a book that gathered Iranian artists under the slogan woman, life, freedom.

5 Her family said she died of grief, a year after the death of her husband, Mattias Ripa. It is the kind of cause a doctor does not certify and a reader of her work does not doubt. She had always written as if private feeling and public history were the same material, seen at different distances.

6 She drew small so that the world could see something large. Her books remain the clearest window many readers will ever have onto a place they were taught to fear, and they will go on doing that work quietly, in black and white, long after the hand that drew them is still.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The three-word sentence “The girl was herself.” most directly functions to
 - A) cast doubt on the accuracy of Satrapi’s account
 - B) reveal the autobiographical basis of the work in a single, quiet stroke
 - C) introduce a fictional character for contrast
 - D) shift the passage from praise to complaint

2. Describing “private feeling and public history” as “the same material, seen at different distances” chiefly serves to

- A) state the governing antithesis that small personal scenes can carry large historical meaning
- B) criticize historians for neglecting private life
- C) summarize the plot of Persepolis for the reader
- D) urge readers to write their own memoirs

Discussion questions:

1. The writer handles an unverifiable cause of death (“her family said she died of grief”) in a single sentence. How does the next line turn that uncertainty into a statement about her work?
2. A tribute risks tipping into sentimentality. Point to two specific choices here (consider the understatement in paragraph 2) that keep the praise restrained rather than gushing.

Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The writer claims that private feeling and public history are 'the same material, seen at different distances.' Defend, challenge, or qualify this claim, using your own reading, study, or experience.